

How to Discern the Truth

The Bereans were called “more fair-minded” because they did not accept claims blindly. They listened carefully, then *“searched the Scriptures daily to find out whether these things were so”* (Acts 17:11). Their example teaches an important truth. Real wisdom is not found in trusting human opinion, tradition, or popular ideas without question. Wisdom begins by testing every claim against the standard of God’s revealed truth.

Scripture reminds believers to be prepared to explain why they believe what they believe. Peter wrote, *“always be ready to give a defense to everyone who asks you a reason for the hope that is in you”* (1 Peter 3:15). A defense requires more than emotion or personal preference. It requires knowledge grounded in God’s Word. Christians are not called to follow blindly, but to think carefully and answer truthfully with humility and reverence.

Paul also urged Timothy to *“rightly divide the word of truth”* (2 Timothy 2:15). This means handling Scripture accurately and diligently. Truth is not determined by culture, philosophy, or majority opinion. God Himself is the source of truth, and His Word provides the standard by which all ideas should be examined.

That is why Paul warned believers: *“Beware lest anyone cheat you through philosophy and empty deceit, according to the tradition of men... and not according to Christ”* (Colossians 2:8). Human reasoning apart from God can sound persuasive while leading people away from truth. Many voices compete for attention in the world, but not all speak truthfully.

The wise person learns to measure every teaching, worldview, and claim against what God has said. Like the Bereans, believers should listen carefully, study faithfully, and seek truth from the One who cannot lie.

Here are several passages that encourage believers to examine, test, and discern truth carefully:

- **Acts 17:11**
“These [Bereans] were more fair-minded than those in Thessalonica, in that they received the word with all readiness, and searched the Scriptures daily to find out whether these things were so.”
The Bereans verified teaching by comparing it with Scripture.
- **1 Thessalonians 5:21**
“Test all things; hold fast what is good.”
Believers are told to examine teachings and cling to what is true.

- **1 John 4:1**
"Beloved, do not believe every spirit, but test the spirits, whether they are of God..."
Christians must discern whether teachings truly come from God.
- **2 Timothy 2:15**
"Be diligent to present yourself approved to God... rightly dividing the word of truth."
Careful study and accurate handling of Scripture are required.
- **Colossians 2:8**
"Beware lest anyone cheat you through philosophy and empty deceit..."
Paul warns against deceptive human ideas that oppose Christ.
- **Hebrews 5:14**
"But solid food belongs to those who are of full age... who by reason of use have their senses exercised to discern both good and evil."
Spiritual maturity develops discernment.
- **Proverbs 14:15**
"The simple believes every word, but the prudent considers well his steps."
Wisdom does not accept claims without examination.
- **John 17:17**
"Sanctify them by Your truth. Your word is truth."
God's Word is the ultimate standard of truth.
- **2 Corinthians 10:5**
"Casting down arguments and every high thing that exalts itself against the knowledge of God..."
Human ideas must be evaluated in light of God's truth.
- **Ephesians 5:10**
"finding out what is acceptable to the Lord."
Believers are called to examine and discern what pleases God.
- **Philippians 1:9–10**
"that your love may abound still more and more in knowledge and all discernment, that you may approve the things that are excellent..."
Discernment relates to spiritual growth and maturity.
- **Romans 12:2**
"Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind..."
Renewed thinking helps believers recognize God's will and truth.

Together, these passages show that God expects believers to think carefully, study diligently, and measure every claim against His revealed truth.

